

Literature Review

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1 Related Work

1.1 Technical Report on a Virtual CTAP2 WebAuthn Authenticator [2]

This technical report covers the development of the associated open source Virtual CTAP2 WebAuthn authenticator. In addition to a software only authenticator it also provides a proof of concept implementation of a Trusted Platform Module (TPM) based authenticator, with associated interfaces and libraries for using a TPM as the underlying credential store. This project wants several improvements we hope to make. First, the authors deliberately keep client-PIN verification outside the TPM, reasoning that the PIN is typed anyway so it "doesn't warrant" TPM protection. This is a waste of modern TPMs' built-in dictionary-attack prevention, which we can enable. Second, their authenticator uses a flat key hierarchy with no dictionary-attack protection on the intermediate key. If we use passkey signing keys as children of an intermediate PIN key that has a lockout policy, then unlocking the PIN key makes them usable just as with Windows Hello and we have brute force protection against the PIN. Third, the paper notes that their method of emulating a USB HID device is fragile. We can build the authenticator as a PAM module for extensibility. Finally, the authenticator supports only ES256, which we could expand to RSA and Ed25519.

1.2 Securing FIDO2 Credentials Using Intel SGX [4]

This paper builds a centralized, replicated FIDO2 credential manager similar to the one we're building, using `/dev/uhid` to emulate a USB HID FIDO2 device like `tpm-fido/VirtualWebAuthn` does. Their conclusion states they want to "improve the Authenticator Emulator to use a local vault (e.g., TPM-based) to store a UID protected by a secret or biometrics" just as we're doing. In fact, Intel has discontinued SGX so the credential manager must be migrated to a TPM anyway.

1.3 The State of Passkeys: Studying the Adoption and Security of Passkeys on the Web [3]

The authors perform a comprehensive security evaluation of passkey implementation in websites. The authors identify lack of standardization and serious security issues in a majority of websites, including use of deprecated cryptographic algorithms and critical or high CVSS scores. The authors present `PASSKEYS-RADAR` for tracking deployment of passkeys on the web, and `PASSKEYS-ATTACKER` for exploiting security vulnerabilities on insecure sites.

1.4 FIDO2, CTAP 2.1, and WebAuthn 2: Provable Security and Post-Quantum Instantiation [1]

The authors formally analyze FIDO2's security with the CTAP 2.1 and WebAuthn 2 sub-protocols. The authors prove post-quantum security for FIDO2 under certain conditions and minor protocol extensions, and show a simple improvement for the downgrade resilience of FIDO2. Since the paper is an abstract proof of CTAP and WebAuthn, the authors do not model some of the new CTAP 2.1 features for enterprise customers, and do not make formal statements about the unlinkability of credentials or other detailed privacy statements. Thus, the implementation of these standards may have unaddressed vulnerabilities.

References

- [1] Nina Bindel, Cas Cremers, and Mang Zhao. FIDO2, CTAP 2.1, and WebAuthn 2: Provable security and post-quantum instantiation. In *2023 IEEE Symposium on Security and Privacy (SP)*, pages 1471–1490. IEEE, 2023. Also available as Cryptology ePrint Archive, Paper 2022/1029: <https://eprint.iacr.org/2022/1029>.

- [2] Chris Culnane, Christopher J. P. Newton, and Helen Treharne. Technical report on a virtual CTAP2 WebAuthn authenticator, 2021. 28 pages, 3 figures, Open Source code repository: <https://github.com/UoS-SCCS/VirtualWebAuthn>.
- [3] Louis Jannett, Andreas Mayer, Maximilian Westers, Vladislav Mladenov, Christian Mainka, and Jörg Schwenk. The state of passkeys: Studying the adoption and security of passkeys on the web. In *35th USENIX Security Symposium (USENIX Security 26)*, pages 5039–5058, Baltimore, MD, August 2026. USENIX Association.
- [4] Tomás Matos, Andre Zuquete, and Tomás Silva. Securing fido2 credentials using intel sgx. In *Proceedings of CYBERSEC 2026: The First International Conference on Security and Cybersecurity in the AI and Digital Context*, Porto, Portugal, 2026. DTR Society Press.